

Migration

Every year, migrating animals take part in immense journeys over land, in the air, and through the oceans. Guided partly by instinct, they arrive at their breeding grounds when the food supply reaches its peak. After raising their young, they head off to their nonbreeding range, where they spend the rest of the year. Some migrant birds can travel more than 30,000 miles (50,000 km) each year. The prospect of extra food and space makes these hard, dangerous journeys worthwhile.

Head contains magnetite, possibly helping the migrant bird sense Earth's magnetic field, like a compass does



Finding the way

Snow geese migrate between the Arctic, where they nest, and the southern United States, where they winter. Like many migrants, their journeys are triggered by the changing length of the days as summer gives way to fall, and as winter gives way to spring. Once they are airborne, they use a range of cues to find their way. These include landmarks, such as coasts and the position of the stars. They even have an internal compass that senses the direction of Earth's magnetic field.

Animals on the move

Arctic terns make a round-trip journey between the Arctic and the Antarctic, traveling at least 20,000 miles (32,000 km) a year. Gray whales travel 12,500 miles (20,000 km)—farther than any other mammal. Monarch butterflies travel up to 3,000 miles (4,800 km).

